UNIVERSITY OF NORTH CAROLINA
CHARLOTTE

WEEK 11 AI DIGEST
SOCIETAL AI IMPACT

Harshavardhan Tumma
Construction & Facilities Engineering

Screenshot of the Headline

Article Publication date: December 02, 2025
Article Number: 21
Title & Link of the article: AI’s impact could worsen gaps between world’s rich and poor, a UN report says

Main Findings and Arguments

•**The "Great Divergence":** Rapid AI adoption risks severely widening the inequality gap between wealthy and developing communities.

•**"People First" Approach:** The UN report argues that the focus must shift from "technology first" to prioritizing human lives and societal well-being.

•**Infrastructure Gaps:** Communities struggling with basic infrastructure, reliable electricity, or internet connectivity risk being permanently left behind in the AI revolution.

Broader Implications for Society

•**Public Value:** AI offers massive potential for faster medical diagnoses, improved weather forecasting, and more transparent disaster risk analysis.

•**Risk of Invisibility:** Vulnerable populations (older individuals, rural communities, those displaced by conflict) risk becoming "invisible" in AI training datasets, causing digital exclusion.

•**Environmental Toll:** Massive AI data centers consume tremendous amounts of electricity and water, stressing local resources globally.

Relevance or Potential Influence on the Construction Industry

•**New Infrastructure Demands:** The exponential growth of AI requires building massive, highly specialized data centers.

•**Civil Engineering & Facility Management Needs:** There is a huge surge in demand to design structures capable of handling extreme electrical/cooling loads and to sustainably operate these complex, automated systems.

•**Industry Inequality:** Smaller construction firms lacking digital tools or capital risk being completely outpaced by larger, tech-enabled corporations.

THANK YOU